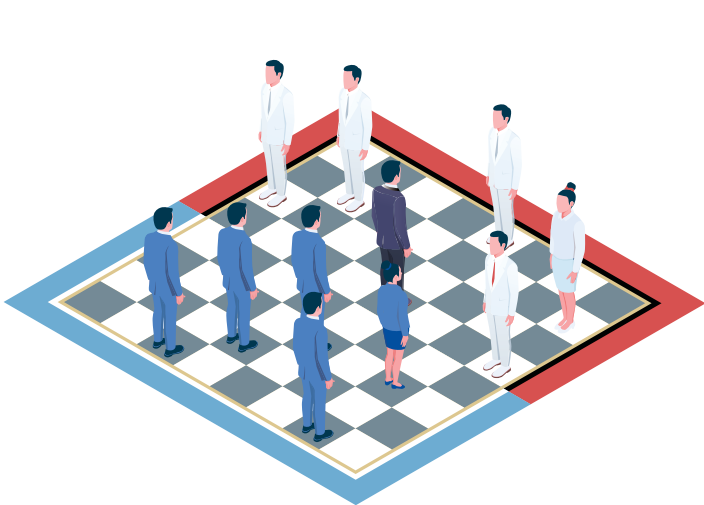


# From Showmanship to Substance



**Quiet Leadership:**  
Purpose and authenticity now outweigh showmanship



**Belief Over Persona:**  
Employees follow ideas, not theatrics



**Changing Expectations:**  
Gen Z demands transparency and

authentic leadership



**Hybrid Demands:**  
Flexibility, empathy, and emotional range sustain trust



**Ambivert Edge:**  
Balancing listening and presence helps navigate complexity

does not fit into the image of a larger-than-life CEO who rallies the room through sheer personality. In today’s hybrid, high-stakes workplaces, leaders who can adapt, listen and lead with quiet confidence are proving far more influential than those who rely on stage presence or chest-thumping.

Shiv Shivakumar, a corporate veteran, management thinker and author, says practical forces are chipping away at the superhero CEO myth. “Most of these so-called superheroes have been found wanting. Look at Jack Welch, Jeff Immelt, and many global bank CEOs and heads of Indian conglomerates,” he says. Also, shorter tenures mean little time to craft a towering image: “The average CEO’s tenure in India is 4.2 years versus 7.2 globally,” says Shivakumar. Market cycles and transpar-

ency intensify the pressure. “Poor FMCG results over the past four years have humbled many, and with social media and platforms like Glassdoor, two-faced CEOs are getting quickly exposed,” adds Shivakumar, who has led Nokia as CEO (Emerging Markets) and PepsiCo Holdings, is Chairman of the Board at Vadilal Industries, and sits on multiple corporate and academic boards.

Vineet Nayar, Founder, Sampark Foundation & former CEO of HCL Technologies, looks at the change through a generational lens. The Gen Z workforce, with abundant opportunities, is amplifying the demand for authenticity and purpose. For them, leadership is not about charisma or showmanship, but about alignment between values and action. “Gen Z is posing sharper questions to prospective

employers: What purpose does this organisation serve beyond profit? Does the culture value people as much as productivity? Is there genuine commitment to society and environment?” says the IT industry veteran. This explains why many young professionals are rejecting traditional corporate paths in favour of start-ups, social ventures, and purpose-led organisations.

Yet, Nayar cautions against confusing personality with substance. “Much is being written about the decline of the extroverted CEO and the rise of the ambivert leader, one who can switch between introvert and extrovert traits. It’s an attractive storyline but misses the essence of leadership,” he says. “Leadership has little to do with whether one is an extrovert, an introvert, or an ambivert. History shows us that people do not follow